

The SAT: The Complete Test Guide

Both sections explained module by module, how the adaptive scoring works, all eight content domains, a 12-week plan, the best free resources, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**2:14**

hours of testing
64 + 70 min, plus a 10-min
break

54+44

Reading & Writing +
Math questions

1600

top score: two sections
of 200–800 each

1029

average total score,
class of 2025

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01 THE TEST AT A GLANCE

Two sections, four modules

The SAT is taken on a laptop or tablet in College Board's Bluebook app. Each section is split into two timed modules, and how you do on the first module decides how hard the second one is.

27 Q

R&W Module 1 • 32 min

27 Q

R&W Module 2 • 32 min

22 Q

Math Module 1 • 35 min

22 Q

Math Module 2 • 35 min

Test structure

Section	Questions & timing	What you do
1 • Reading and Writing	54 questions 64 min (2 × 32) Score 200–800	Read short passages (25–150 words), each with one question . Texts come from literature, history, social studies, the humanities and science, and some include a table or graph. Every question is multiple choice with four options.
Break	10 minutes	Between the sections. You can't go back to Reading and Writing once Math starts.
2 • Math	44 questions 70 min (2 × 35) Score 200–800	About 75% multiple choice and 25% student-produced response , where you type the answer. A calculator is allowed on every question, and the Desmos graphing calculator is built in. About 30% of questions use a real-world context.

ADAPTIVE BY MODULE

Module 1 decides Module 2

Module 1 mixes easy, medium and hard questions. Do well and you get a harder Module 2, which unlocks the top of the score range. Inside a module you can skip, flag and return to any question.

UNSCORED QUESTIONS

A few questions don't count

Each section includes a small number of **pretest** questions that College Board is trying out. They don't affect your score, and you can't tell which ones they are, so give every question your best effort.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, take one full practice test in Bluebook, then follow the 12-week roadmap on page 8.

Mid-prep?

Study the traps on page 7 and drill the weakest domains you find on pages 4 and 6.

Test in weeks?

Do the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan on page 8.



Pigo's tip: There's no penalty for wrong answers. Never leave a question blank, even with seconds left on the clock.

SECTION 1

02

The Reading and Writing section

Two 32-minute modules of 27 questions each. Every question has its own short passage, so you never have to hold a long text in your head for ten questions.

27

questions per module

~71 sec

per question

25–150

words per passage

0

points lost for a wrong answer

How the questions are split by domain

College Board gives a range of questions for each domain out of 54. Bars show the minimum to maximum.

Craft and Structure

Words in context, purpose, cross-text

Information and Ideas

Central ideas, evidence, inferences

Standard English

Conventions

Boundaries; form, structure, sense

Expression of Ideas

Rhetorical synthesis, transitions



~28%

~26%

~26%

~20%

Questions come in a set order. Each module runs Craft and Structure → Information and Ideas → Standard English Conventions → Expression of Ideas, and within each group the easier questions come first. Conventions and Expression of Ideas are almost half the section and follow learnable rules, so they are the fastest points to raise.

Strategies that work on this section

- Answer from the text, not from what you know.** The right choice is always supported by the passage, even if another choice is a true fact.
- Predict before you look.** On words-in-context questions, say your own word for the blank, then match it to a choice.
- Read the goal first on "notes" questions.** Rhetorical synthesis asks you to meet a stated goal. Pick the choice that does exactly that.
- Bank the grammar.** Once you know the rules, Conventions questions take 30–45 seconds. Spend the time you save on inferences.
- Use the Bluebook tools.** Highlight, cross out choices and flag questions to revisit before the module ends.
- Watch for extreme words.** "Always", "proves" and "entirely" are rarely supported by a 100-word passage.
- Two minutes is the limit.** If a question passes two minutes, pick your best guess, flag it and move on.
- Read tables carefully.** For quantitative evidence, check the exact row, column and units the claim refers to.



Pigo's tip: Hard questions in Module 1 matter most. Getting them right is what sends you to the harder Module 2.

03

WHAT THE SECTION TESTS

Reading & Writing skills, in plain English

Every question in the section belongs to one of these four domains.

DOMAIN

1

~26%

Information and Ideas

Understanding what a text says and what it proves.

Question types: Central Ideas and Details; Command of Evidence (textual and quantitative); Inferences.

Be ready to: find a text's main idea, choose the quote or data that best supports a claim, and finish a passage with its most logical conclusion.

DOMAIN

2

~28%

Craft and Structure

How and why a text is written.

Question types: Words in Context; Text Structure and Purpose; Cross-Text Connections.

Be ready to: choose the most precise word, name what a sentence does in a passage, and predict how one author would respond to another.

DOMAIN

3

~20%

Expression of Ideas

Revising writing so it meets a goal.

Question types: Rhetorical Synthesis (bulleted student notes); Transitions.

Be ready to: use only the notes that accomplish the stated goal, and choose the transition that shows the right logical link.

DOMAIN

4

~26%

Standard English Conventions

The rules of grammar and punctuation.

Question types: Boundaries; Form, Structure, and Sense.

Be ready to: join and separate clauses with the right punctuation, make subjects and verbs agree, and choose the right tense, pronoun and possessive.

Grammar rules cheat sheet

Rule	Example
A semicolon works like a period	It joins two complete sentences: <i>The lab closed early; the samples were already frozen.</i>
A colon follows a complete sentence	It introduces a list, an explanation or an example: <i>She had one goal: finishing the race.</i>
Comma + FANBOYS joins sentences	<i>for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so.</i> A comma alone between two sentences is a comma splice.
Extra information gets a matching pair	Two commas or two dashes around a non-essential phrase, never one of each.
Skip the phrase to find the subject	<i>The list of supplies is long.</i> The subject is "list", not "supplies".
No comma between subject and verb	<i>The scientists who ran the study found...</i> (no comma before "found").
Possessives and contractions	<i>its</i> = belonging to it; <i>it's</i> = it is; <i>the researchers'</i> data = belonging to several researchers.
Modifiers touch what they describe	<i>Walking home, Maya saw a fox,</i> not <i>Walking home, a fox was seen by Maya.</i>

TRANSITIONS TO KNOW

Contrast: however, nevertheless, by contrast, still • **Result:** therefore, thus, consequently • **Addition:** moreover, furthermore, in addition • **Example:** for example, for instance • **Similarity:** similarly, likewise • **Time:** meanwhile, subsequently, finally

04 SECTION 2 The Math section

Two 35-minute modules of 22 questions each. You can use a calculator on every question, and the Desmos graphing calculator is built into Bluebook.

22

questions per module

~95 sec

per question

~25%

student-produced responses

100%

of questions allow a calculator

● How the questions are split by domain

Questions out of 44 for each domain. Bars show the minimum to maximum.

Algebra

Linear equations, functions, systems

Advanced Math

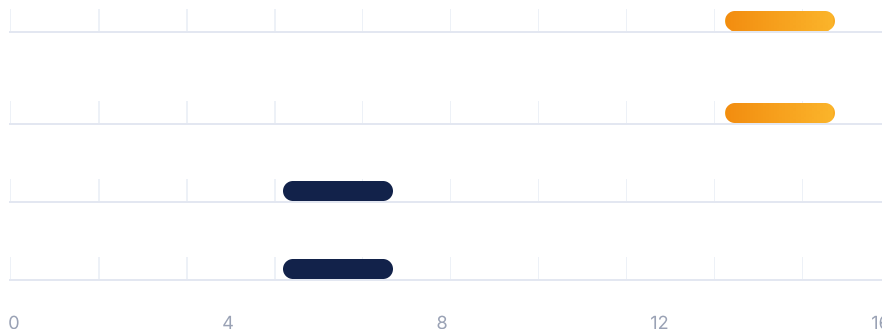
Quadratics, exponentials, nonlinear

Problem-Solving & Data

Ratios, percents, statistics

Geometry & Trigonometry

Area, triangles, circles, trig



~35%

~35%

~15%

~15%

What this means for your study time: Algebra and Advanced Math are 70% of the section. Fluency with linear equations, systems, quadratics and function notation moves your score faster than anything else.

TYPING YOUR ANSWER

Student-produced response rules

- Up to 5 characters for a positive answer, 6 for a negative one (the minus sign counts).
- Fractions or decimals are both fine. Don't enter mixed numbers: type $7/2$ or 3.5 , not $3\frac{1}{2}$.
- If a decimal is too long, round or cut it at the fourth digit: $2/3$ can be $.6666$ or $.6667$.
- No units, %, \$ or commas. If more than one answer works, enter just one.

FIVE DESMOS MOVES

Let the calculator do the algebra

- Graph both sides of an equation and click the intersection.
- Type a quadratic and click its vertex or x-intercepts.
- Add a slider for an unknown constant like k .
- Paste a table and run $y_1 \sim mx_1 + b$ for a line of best fit.
- Check two expressions are equivalent by graphing both.

● Strategies that work on this section

- Read the last line twice.** Are they asking for x , or for $2x + 1$? Many wrong choices are right answers to a different question.
- Plug in or back-solve.** When algebra gets messy, test the answer choices or pick easy numbers for variables.
- Know the reference sheet by heart.** It's there on test day, but opening it costs time.
- Check units in word problems.** Convert minutes to hours, or percents to decimals, before you calculate.



Pigo's tip: Questions get harder as a module goes on. Early questions count the same, so don't rush them.

05

WHAT THE SECTION TESTS

Math skills, in plain English

Every Math question belongs to one of these four domains.

DOMAIN

1

~35%

Algebra

Linear relationships, in every form.

Question types: linear equations in one and two variables; linear functions; systems of two linear equations; linear inequalities.

Be ready to: write an equation from a word problem, explain slope and intercept in context, and tell when a system has no solution or infinitely many.

DOMAIN

2

~35%

Advanced Math

Nonlinear equations and functions.

Question types: equivalent expressions; nonlinear equations and systems; quadratic, exponential, polynomial, rational, radical and absolute value functions.

Be ready to: factor and complete the square, use the vertex and discriminant, model exponential growth and decay, and shift or stretch graphs.

DOMAIN

3

~15%

Problem-Solving & Data Analysis

Numbers from the real world.

Question types: ratios, rates, proportions and units; percentages; one- and two-variable data; probability; sample statistics and margin of error.

Be ready to: find percent change, read scatterplots and lines of best fit, compare mean and median with outliers, and use a two-way table.

DOMAIN

4

~15%

Geometry & Trigonometry

Shapes, angles and right-triangle trig.

Question types: area and volume; lines, angles and triangles; right triangles and trigonometry; circles.

Be ready to: use similar triangles and the Pythagorean theorem, apply SOH-CAH-TOA and radians, and find arc length, sector area and a circle's equation.

Formulas to know cold

Idea	Formula	When it shows up
Slope	$m = (y_2 - y_1) / (x_2 - x_1)$	Lines through two points; rate of change in context
Vertex of a parabola	$x = -b / (2a)$	Maximum or minimum of a quadratic
Discriminant	$b^2 - 4ac$: >0 two, =0 one, <0 no real solutions	"How many solutions?" and "for what value of k ?"
Sum and product of roots	sum = $-b/a$, product = c/a	Quadratics you'd rather not solve
Exponential model	$y = a(1 \pm r)^t$	Growth or decay by a percent each period
Percent change	$(\text{new} - \text{old}) / \text{old} \times 100$	Prices, populations, data tables
Circle	$(x - h)^2 + (y - k)^2 = r^2$	Complete the square to find center and radius
Arcs and sectors	arc = $(\theta/360) \cdot 2\pi r$, sector = $(\theta/360) \cdot \pi r^2$	Circle questions in degrees; π radians = 180°
Complementary angles	$\sin x^\circ = \cos(90 - x)^\circ$	Trig questions that look impossible at first

06

LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before test day.

Typed 3 1/2? I'll take that point!



01 Answering the wrong question

You solve for x , but the question asked for $x + 3$ or $2x$. Reread the last line before you choose.

02 True but off-target choices

On Reading and Writing, a choice can be accurate and still not answer the question or meet the goal.

03 Bringing in outside knowledge

If the passage doesn't support it, it's wrong, even if it's a real fact you learned in class.

04 Comma splices

Two complete sentences need a period, semicolon, or comma + FANBOYS. A comma alone is never enough.

05 Extreme answer choices

"Always", "proves" and "entirely" are rarely backed up by a short passage. Prefer measured claims.

06 Ignoring units

Minutes vs hours, percent vs decimal, feet vs inches. Convert before you calculate.

07 Rushing Module 1

Module 1 decides how high you can score. Accuracy there matters more than finishing early.

08 Typing an invalid answer

Mixed numbers like $3 \frac{1}{2}$ can be misread. Enter $\frac{7}{2}$ or 3.5, and leave off units and % signs.

09 Skipping Desmos

Many system and quadratic questions take 15 seconds in Desmos and two minutes by hand.

10 Leaving blanks

There's no penalty for wrong answers. Guess, flag the question, and return if time allows.

Quick self-check: If $3x + 5 = 20$, what is $6x + 10$? (Answer: 40. Double both sides of the equation; you never need to find x .)

07 PLAN YOUR PREP Your 12-week study roadmap

A steady plan beats cramming. Three or four focused sessions a week is enough for most students, as long as every session ends with reviewing mistakes.

- Week 1**
Baseline
 - **Baseline test** Full test
Take a full practice test in Bluebook under real timing. Log every miss by domain and skill in a mistake journal.
- Weeks 2–4**
Foundations
 - **Grammar and Algebra**
Learn the conventions rules on page 4 and the linear-equation toolkit. Do 20 Question Bank questions a day.
- Weeks 5–7**
Core skills
 - **Advanced Math and evidence**
Quadratics, exponentials, Information and Ideas. Learn the five Desmos moves. One timed module each weekend.
- Week 8**
Checkpoint
 - **Second full test** Full test
Compare each domain with Week 1. Re-aim the next four weeks at what's still weakest.
- Weeks 9–10**
Hard questions
 - **Push the ceiling**
Filter the Question Bank to hard questions in Craft and Structure, data analysis, geometry and trig.
- Weeks 11–12**
Test mode
 - **Full tests and review** Full test
Two more full tests on test-day mornings. Review every miss, then go light in the last two days.

● The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Full practice test, then review every miss by domain	Name your three weakest skills
3 weeks out	Drill those three skills; one timed module per section	80% or better on those skills
2 weeks out	Full practice test at the time of day you'll test	Finish every module on time
Final week	Light review of grammar rules and formulas; complete exam setup in Bluebook	Rest the night before

How to keep a mistake journal: for every miss, write the domain, why you missed it (didn't know it, misread, ran out of time) and the rule that would have saved you. Reread it before each full test.

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 practice questions

Original, SAT-style and pitched hard. For 1–4, pick the most logical, precise and standard completion. Calculator OK on 6–10. Allow **15 minutes**.

1 R&W • WORDS IN CONTEXT

Although the committee's report was praised for its thoroughness, critics noted that its recommendations were largely ____: they restated policies already in place rather than proposing anything new.

- A** innovative **B** redundant **C** controversial **D** ambiguous

2 R&W • BOUNDARIES

In 1928, Alexander Fleming noticed that mold had killed the bacteria in one of his culture ____ this accidental observation eventually led to the development of penicillin.

- A** dishes, **B** dishes; **C** dishes **D** dishes, and,

3 R&W • FORM, STRUCTURE, SENSE

The collection of letters written by the Brontë sisters, now housed in several different libraries, ____ scholars insight into the family's daily life.

- A** give **B** have given **C** gives **D** are giving

4 R&W • TRANSITIONS

Coral reefs cover less than 1% of the ocean floor. ____ they support roughly a quarter of all known marine species.

- A** Therefore, **B** Similarly, **C** Nevertheless, **D** For instance,

5 R&W • RHETORICAL SYNTHESIS

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes: • Maria Sibylla Merian (1647–1717) was a German-born naturalist and illustrator. In 1699, she traveled to Suriname to study insects. • Her 1705 book *Metamorphosis insectorum Surinamensium* showed insects alongside the plants they lived on. • Earlier illustrators had often drawn insects in isolation.

The student wants to emphasize how Merian's work differed from earlier illustrations. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes?

- A** Merian, a German-born naturalist, traveled to Suriname in 1699 to study insects.
B Unlike earlier illustrators, who often drew insects in isolation, Merian showed insects alongside the plants they lived on.
C Merian's book about the insects of Suriname was published in 1705.
D Merian was both a naturalist and an illustrator who lived from 1647 to 1717.

6 MATH • ALGEBRA

Line ℓ passes through $(2, 7)$ and $(6, -1)$. What is the y -coordinate of its y -intercept?

Student-produced response: enter your answer

7 MATH • ADVANCED MATH

The function $f(x) = 2x^2 - 12x + c$, where c is a constant, has a minimum value of 5. What is the value of c ?

- A** 5 **B** 18 **C** 23 **D** 41

8 MATH • PROBLEM-SOLVING & DATA

The price of a jacket is increased by 20%. The new price is then decreased by 25%. The final price is what percent of the original price?

- A** 85% **B** 90% **C** 95% **D** 105%

9 MATH • GEOMETRY & TRIG

In right triangle ABC , angle C is a right angle and $\sin A = 0.6$. What is the value of $\tan B$?

- A** $3/4$ **B** $4/5$ **C** $4/3$ **D** $5/3$

10 MATH • ADVANCED MATH

$y = x^2 - 4x + 7$ and $y = 2x - 2$. The solution to the system is (a, b) . What is the value of b ?

Student-produced response: enter your answer

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the test.

#	Answer	Why
1	B	The colon explains the blank: the recommendations "restated policies already in place." Repeating what already exists is redundant . "Innovative" is the opposite, and nothing suggests controversy or unclear meaning.
2	B	Both sides are complete sentences, so a semicolon joins them. A is a comma splice, C is a run-on, and D adds an incorrect comma after "and."
3	C	The subject is collection , which is singular. Skip "of letters written by the Brontë sisters" and the phrase between commas: the collection gives .
4	C	A tiny area supporting a huge share of species is a surprising contrast. Nevertheless signals exactly that. "Therefore" would mean the small area caused the diversity.
5	B	The goal is a difference from earlier work. Only B compares Merian with earlier illustrators. The other choices are accurate but don't meet the goal.
6	11	Slope = $(-1 - 7)/(6 - 2) = -2$. Substitute (2, 7): $7 = -2(2) + b$, so $b = 11$. In Desmos, type the two points and fit $y_1 \sim mx_1 + b$ to check.
7	C	The minimum is at the vertex, $x = -(-12)/(2 \cdot 2) = 3$. $f(3) = 18 - 36 + c = c - 18 = 5$, so $c = 23$.
8	B	Percent changes multiply: $1.20 \times 0.75 = 0.90$, or 90%. Adding them ($+20\% - 25\% = -5\%$) gives the trap answer, 95%.
9	C	$\sin A = 0.6 = 3/5$, so the side opposite A (BC) is 3 and the hypotenuse is 5, making $AC = 4$. $\tan B = \text{opposite/adjacent} = AC/BC = 4/3$.
10	4	Set the equations equal: $x^2 - 6x + 9 = 0$, so $(x - 3)^2 = 0$ and $x = 3$. Then $b = 2(3) - 2 = 4$. In Desmos the line touches the parabola at (3, 4).

What your score tells you

9–10

Strong. Move on to full-length Bluebook tests and hard Question Bank sets.

6–8

On track. Revisit the domain behind every miss on pages 4 and 6.

0–5

Build foundations. Start with the grammar rules and Algebra before you time yourself.



Pigo's tip: Write down why you missed a question, not just the right answer. Patterns show up fast.

10

KNOW THE TARGET

Scores & 2026–27 test dates

Your total score is the sum of the Reading and Writing and Math section scores, each from 200 to 800.

1029

average total score, class of 2025 (about 2 million test takers)

1010

median (50th percentile) total score, class of 2025

1200

75th percentile: scoring here beats about 3 in 4 test takers

480 / 530

College Board's readiness benchmarks for R&W / Math

• Where scores fall (class of 2025)

Total-score ranges for the middle half of test takers, from College Board's 2025 annual report.

Total score

25th to 75th percentile



850–1200

Middle half by section: Reading and Writing 430–610, Math 410–600.

Set your own target from your college list. Look up each college's middle-50% SAT range (in its Common Data Set, section C9, or admissions page) and aim for the upper half of that range.

• 2026–27 SAT weekend test dates

Test date	Register by	Late registration (fee)	Good for
November 7, 2026	October 23	October 27	Seniors' last early-round option at many colleges
December 5, 2026	November 20	November 24	Regular-decision seniors; juniors' first try
March 6, 2027	February 19	February 23	Juniors after winter prep
May 1, 2027	April 16	April 20	Juniors; plan around AP exams
June 5, 2027	May 21	May 25	Juniors' retake before summer

August 22, September 12 and October 3, 2026 have already passed. Dates from College Board's 2026–27 calendar; always confirm on sat.collegeboard.org before you register. Many schools also offer the SAT free on a school day.

Score Choice and superscoring

You choose which test dates to send, though some colleges ask for all scores. Many colleges superscore, combining your best section scores across dates.

Free score reports

Registration includes free score sends to four colleges, usable until 9 days after your test date.

YOUR TOOLKIT

11

Free resources & test-day checklist

The best SAT prep material is free and comes from College Board itself. Here's what to use and when.

1

Bluebook practice tests FREE

bluebook.collegeboard.org

Full-length adaptive practice tests that look and score like the real SAT. Review answers in My Practice afterward.

2

Official SAT Practice on Khan Academy FREE

khanacademy.org/digital-sat

Free lessons and practice for every skill, built with College Board. Great for Weeks 2–7.

3

SAT Suite Question Bank FREE

satsuitequestionbank.collegeboard.org

Real-style questions you can filter by domain, skill and difficulty. Use it to drill hard questions.

4

Desmos graphing calculator FREE

desmos.com/calculator

The same calculator that's built into Bluebook. Practice the five moves on page 5 until they're automatic.

5

SAT Skills Insight FREE

satsuite.collegeboard.org

Shows the skills students in each score band usually have, so you can see what the next band needs.

6

ACT SAT GO free practice tests FREE

actsatgo.com

Timed practice tests with a score report, plus a free diagnostic lesson with a tutor.

• Test-day checklist

- ☐ Bluebook installed and updated, with exam setup completed in the days before the test
- ☐ Admission ticket from Bluebook, printed or saved
- ☐ Acceptable photo ID
- ☐ Device fully charged, plus a charger or power cord
- ☐ Pencils or pens for the scratch paper you'll be given
- ☐ An approved calculator (optional; Desmos is built in)
- ☐ Snack and water for the break
- ☐ Arrive by 7:45 a.m.; doors usually close at 8:00
- ☐ Phone off and put away for the whole test
- ☐ A good night's sleep. No new material the night before.

Testing with accommodations? Apply through your school's SSD coordinator well before your registration deadline. Approved accommodations carry over to future SAT dates.



Pigo's tip: Do your last full practice test at 8 a.m. on a Saturday. Your brain will know the routine on test day.

ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 SAT TUTORING

Aiming for 1500+? Get a personal SAT plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest skills, review your practice tests, and give you a week-by-week plan to test day.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



Scan to book
www.actsatgo.com/consultation



Concept tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all eight domains, with Desmos drills built in.

Full-length mocks

Adaptive practice tests with score reports, so you see progress before test day.

Mistake review

We go through every miss with you and turn the patterns into a plan.

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